

THE ROMA PROJECTS

In recent years, many readers have certainly noticed a curious and troubling phenomenon in everyday office printing: the digital typographic era—especially when paired with low-quality print technology—has begun to reveal imperfections that traditional ink-bleed once concealed.

Times New Roman, once a dependable classic, now feels strangely lifeless and distracting both on screen and on paper, demanding a considerable effort from the reader far beyond what its original design intended. Indeed, many still prefer reading physical printouts simply to focus on the text.

At the same time, PDF rendering engines vary dramatically. The exact same file opened in Adobe Reader can appear thin and overly smoothed, whereas in Microsoft Edge or SumatraPDF it regains weight, clarity, and balance. This discrepancy seems largely unaccounted for by professional typographers—with notable exceptions like Matthew Butterick's *Equity* and Robert Slimbach's *Minion*.

Even highly regarded fonts suffer from this inconsistency. Open-source classics like *Crimson* and *Garamond* are often rendered almost unrecognizable by standard office printers and default PDF viewers, reducing hours, weeks, or years of typographic craftsmanship to ashes.

Since keeping an offset press in every office is hardly practical, we sought a different approach: a typeface designed to anticipate and counter the quirks of Adobe Reader, inkjet printers, laser printers, and smart-tank systems—or, at the very least, to strike a better balance among them.

Developed with patience, curiosity, and no claim to professional typographic mastery, this project takes Sebastian Kosch's 2012 open-source *Crimson* as its foundation. In our view, its

innate elegance has long deserved a modern reinterpretation to reclaim its place among the finest everyday serif typefaces.

We kindly suggest viewing this PDF first in Edge or SumatraPDF, and only then in Adobe Reader, to experience firsthand how starkly different the rendering results can be.

This document presents a series of exploratory tests performed on Crimson Roman within the context of legal and academic writing. Using FontForge, these samples were evaluated both on screen and in print to understand how Crimson behaves under various typographic adjustments in today's digital-first, low-cost print environments.

These observations are practical, user-level findings supported by AI-assisted analysis (Microsoft Copilot), focusing on paragraph color, x-height behavior, Roman/Italic balance, and OTF/TTF rendering robustness.

Ultimately, this document illustrates the challenges of deploying Crimson in long-form legal text and showcases the adjustments that yielded the most promising results. All modifications presented here are working drafts rather than final design proposals.

Typographic options

1. Option 1 — 102%, x-height 445, leading 290, OTF: Best for display? (Amor).

2. Option 2 — Style 1, 102%, x-height 445, leading 270, TTF: Best for PDF and office printing? AI's favourite. (Roma)

3. Option 3 — Style 2, 102%, x-height 450, leading 290, OTF: Best for print, poor-print and display? (Roma B).

4. Option 4 — Style 1, 102%, x-height 445, Leading 250, TTF: Best for PDF and office printing? (Roma 250)

5. Option 5 — Style 2, 102%, x-height 450, leading 250, TTF: Best for print, poor-print and display? (Roma B 250).

Original (Crimson Roman)

Changes:

Style: ---

Scale uniformly: ---

X-height: ---

Typo line gap: ---

Format: Open Type

If the expression “Compliance Law” were to be described — as the evolution of its legal regime now appears to demand — as “all those regulations by virtue of which an undertaking would be required to adopt, pursue, and enforce, within its business and trade, an overriding public interest as if it were one of its own governance purposes or profit-making interests”, surely the industry and the public, particularly in common-law jurisdictions, would always react with a considerable amount of surprise, if not outright challenge and defiance.

E F R P K k y

OPTION 1. (Amor)

From “Crimson Roman” on “Font Forge”

Changes:

Style: ---

Scale uniformly: 102 %

X-height: 445

Typo line gap: 290

Format: Open Type

If the expression “Compliance Law” were to be described — as the evolution of its legal regime now appears to demand — as “all those regulations by virtue of which an undertaking would be required to adopt, pursue, and enforce, within its business and trade, an overriding public interest as if it were one of its own governance purposes or profit-making interests”, surely the industry and the public, particularly in common-law jurisdictions, would always react with a considerable amount of surprise, if not outright challenge and defiance.

E F R P K k y

This update includes several small glyph refinements.

Best for display (OTF)?

OPTION 2. (Roma)

From “Crimson Roman” on “Font Forge”

Changes:

Style: 1

Scale uniformly: 102 %

X-height: 445

Typo line gap: 270

Format: True Type

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This update includes several small glyph refinements.

Best for pdf printing?

MS COPILOT favourite version (and ours!)

OPTION 3. (Roma B)

From “Crimson Roman” on “Font Forge”

Changes:

Style: 2

Scale uniformly: 102 %

X-height: 450

Typo line gap: 290

Format: True Type

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E F R P K k y

Best for regular print, poor-print and display?

OPTION 4. (Roma 250)

From “Crimson Roman” on “Font Forge”

Changes:

Style: 2

Scale uniformly: 102 %

X-height: 450

Typo line gap: 250

Format: True Type

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E F R P K k y

This update includes several small glyph refinements.

OPTION 5. (Roma B 250)

From “Crimson Roman” on “Font Forge”

Changes:

Style: 2

Scale uniformly: 102 %

X-height: 450

Typo line gap: 250

Format: True Type

If the expression “Compliance Law” were to be described — as the evolution of its legal regime now appears to demand — as “all those regulations by virtue of which an undertaking would be required to adopt, pursue, and enforce, within its business and trade, an overriding public interest as if it were one of its own governance purposes or profit-making interests”, surely the industry and the public, particularly in common-law jurisdictions, would always react with a considerable amount of surprise, if not outright challenge and defiance.

E F R P K k y

This update includes several small glyph refinements.

OPTION 1, Comparison with Times New Roman (AMOR):

If the expression “Compliance Law” were to be described — as the evolution of its legal regime now appears to demand — as “all those regulations by virtue of which an undertaking would be required to adopt, pursue, and enforce, within its business and trade, an overriding public interest as if it were one of its own governance or profit-making purposes”, surely the industry and the public — particularly in common-law jurisdictions — would always react with considerable surprise, if not outright challenge and defiance. (size 12 pts, leading 1 pt)

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OPTION 2, Comparison with Times New Roman (ROMA):

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OPTION 3, Comparison with Times New Roman (ROMA B):

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OPTION 4, Comparison with Times New Roman (ROMA 250):

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OPTION 5, Comparison with Times New Roman (ROMA B 250):

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Conclusions

The exploratory adjustments presented in this document highlight how Crimson Roman behaves under different typographic conditions relevant to legal and academic writing. While the original design offers exceptional elegance and classical balance, its low x-height, delicate outlines, and narrow lowercase proportions present challenges in modern digital workflows and low-quality office printing.

Among the tested configurations, the variant using Style 2, x-height 450, uniform scaling at 102%, and TrueType export demonstrated the most balanced performance. This combination — particularly when paired with a reduced line gap of 250 rather than 290 — produced a stronger paragraph colour, improved vertical rhythm, enhanced legibility at smaller sizes (10, 11 and 11.5 pts), and greater robustness in print, while preserving much of Crimson’s original character.

These results, however, should not be interpreted as definitive typographic solutions, but rather as practical observations from real-world usage. They suggest that Crimson has significant potential for professional legal and academic contexts if revisited with contemporary production realities in mind. Therefore, the intention of this document is simply to provide a clear illustration of the issues encountered and the adjustments that yielded the most promising behaviour. Any refinement or redesign would naturally benefit from expert typographic guidance and a deeper understanding of Crimson’s design philosophy.

Within the reduced set of exploratory variants presented here, a clear functional distinction emerged between Roma and Roma B. Roma, using Style 1 and a moderate x-height increase to 445, preserves much of Crimson’s original elegance and classical balance, making it visually closer to the design philosophy of the source. Roma B, by contrast, with Style 2 and an x-height of 450, offers greater versatility for everyday use, providing stronger paragraph colour, improved legibility at common text sizes, and more robust performance across digital reading and office-printing environments. This distinction became even clearer when comparing line gaps of 290 and 250, with the latter producing a more cohesive and authoritative text block. Rather than a hierarchy of quality, these variants represent two complementary interpretations of Crimson adapted to contemporary workflows.

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In fact, as they might ultimately observe, in its essence “compliance” could not amount to anything more than the mere “act of obeying a law or rule, especially one that controls a particular industry or type of work”, as the Cambridge Dictionary specifies and illustrates with the example: “this cake was made in strict compliance with its recipe”, from which the industry framed its understanding of the term as the “specific requirements applicable to a service or product intended to be made available in a public market”.

Consequently — as it would further be concluded — just as civil and commercial law were to stand as the law of individuals, prescribing and proscribing their actions and behaviour, “compliance law”, in turn, would stand as the “law of products and services”, thereby requiring, to name only a few examples, lawyers to offer their services in accordance with applicable professional ethics (conflict of interest, independence, probity, good faith, etc.); manufacturers to place toys, electrical devices, cosmetics, or medicines on the market only after ensuring they pose no hazards to the public (product compliance); and financial institutions to grant loans or undertake investments without breaching minimum capital and solvency requirements.

Notwithstanding, while such statements must indeed be acknowledged as true — and compliance, therefore, understood, by default, as the legal regime governing the public marketing of certain products and services (the “law of all regulated markets”) — it must equally be outlined that, at the same time, such a narrow description would nonetheless fail to fully address or express the true substance (...)

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